

Enabling the Next Generation of Contributors to R

Tidy team meeting

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Project Overview

Background

The Research Software Maintenance Fund supports projects that improve sustainability, reduce technical debt, and enhance community engagement.

Our RSMF-funded project, *Enabling the Next Generation of Contributors to R*, aims to put the R project on a more sustainable footing.

Aims

1. Build collaboration between R Core developers and advanced contributors
2. Support broader engagement in R contribution.
3. Improve communication between R Core and the wider community.
4. Improve the sustainability of the R Foundation

WP1: Mentored cohort

Mentored cohort: Who's involved

Mentees (10-20% FTE)

- RSMF-funded: Gabe Becker, Kylie Bemis, Mikael Jagan, Jeroen Ooms
- Partner-funded: Kevin Ushey (Posit), Mossa Reimert (A2-Ai), Mike Chirico (Google)

R Core mentors:

- RSMF-funded (10% FTE): Simon Urbanek, Peter Dalgaard
- Ad-hoc: Michael Lawrence, Paul Murrell, Kurt Hornik

Triage Team

- Established Triage Team with mentee cohort + Lluís Revilla and Ivan Krylov
- Distributed Bugzilla components, e.g. Kevin allocated I/O, Low-level and Windows
- Developed [Triaging Team Guidelines](#)
 - Basic review: duplicate? contributed package? ...
 - Deeper review: repro? root cause? proposed solution?

Triaging progress

Since TRIAGED status introduced (21 April 2026)

Current Status	Resolution	Count
TRIAGED		11
CLOSED	FIXED	4
CLOSED	WONTFIX	1
CONFIRMED		1
REOPENED		1
Total		18

Mentored projects

Projects supporting development/maintenance of R, including

- Jeroen Ooms: GitHub actions for checking CRAN packages on Linux ARM 64:
<https://github.com/r-devel/linux-arm64-checks>
- Kevin Ushey: Fuzz testing R to identify edge cases and bugs
- Gabe Becker: Updating `install.package()` to use local dependencies with `repos = NULL`
- Mikael Jagan: Reviewing results from `rchk`

WP2: Supporting Broader Engagement

Engagement: Who's involved

RSMF-funded RSEs/community managers

- Heather Turner (70% FTE)
- Ella Kaye (30% FTE)

Translation team

- Weblate admins (ad-hoc): Gergely Daróczi, Mike Chirico
- RSMF contractors: Fernando Corrêa, Beatriz Milz

Engagement Activities (so far)

- [R Contributor Office Hours](#)
- R Dev Days:
 - Rencontres R, June 19, Nantes
 - CascadiaR, June 26, Portland
 - useR! 2026, July 10, Warsaw
- R Project Sprint 2026, 1-3 September, Birmingham
- Maintaining infrastructure: [R Dev Container](#)
- Maintain links with Forwards, RLadies+, rainbowR

Engagement Activities (roadmap)

- Develop and implement and a project wide Code of Conduct
- Evolve the development infrastructure
 - Improve Weblate administration and integration of translations
 - Pilot an enhancements discussion process
 - Explore options for integrated development platforms

WP3: Improving Communication

Communication: Who's involved

RSMF-funded RSEs/community managers (Heather Turner and Ella Kaye)

RSMF team and partners (whole team) as contributors

Communication: Activities (so far)

- R Project Zulip
 - Migrating R Contributor Slack and expanding scope
 - Standard cloud instance supported by Zulip under open source programme
 - Inviting RSMF whole team, R Contribution WG and R Foundation this week
 - Full launch late September
- Establish R Foundation social media team

Communication: Activities (roadmap)

- Pilot Discourse as an alternative to the r-project mailing lists
- Expand use of the R Project website, R Blog and R Foundation social media accounts to engage potential contributors

WP4: Sustainability of the R Foundation

Overview

Who's involved:

- RSMF-funded: Heather Turner
- Ad-hoc: R Foundation members

Roadmap:

- Propose new organisational structure enabling wider community representation
- Establish new channels for fundraising

Partners

Partners: Who's involved

- R Consortium: funding for R Project Sprints, travel funding for RSMF team
- R Foundation: mentoring, travel funding for R Core to attend events
- Google: mentee time and travel funding
- A2-Ai: mentee time and travel funding, additional staff time
- Posit: mentee time and travel funding, **additional extra time as needed from the broader tidyverse team** (~1 day/week person-time across the team)

Opportunities

Bug triage

Current components with no one allocated as triager:

- Add-ons (7): package-related issues, issues in R Core maintained packages
- Models (28): lm, glm, lme, etc

Triage team has more expertise in software engineering than statistics - Analyses component could be passed on.

Mini projects (1)

Low-level

- Type and shape annotations to R (Michael Lawrence) [#51](#)
- Versioning of formal classes (Gabe Becker) [#19](#)
- Apply security fixes to old releases [#17](#)
- Using LLMs to identify bottlenecks (Robert Gentleman) [#14](#)
- Extended testing of R-devel [#5](#)

Math

- Accuracy of mathematical functions (Mikael Jagan) [#9](#)

Mini projects (2)

Doc

- Review R-intro and R-FAQ (Deepayan Sarkar) [#15](#), [#16](#)
- Modernising CRAN website (Kurt Hornik) [#10](#)
- Demystifying Autotools, pkg-config in blog post [#8](#)

CRAN

- Broader testing of CRAN packages (Kurt Hornik) [#7](#)
- Using AI to enhance the CRAN check (Kurt Hornik, A2-Ai) [#3](#)
- Testing ALTREP and C-level access patterns [#12](#)

Engagement

- R Dev Container development
 - Local use on macOS and Windows
 - Using Positron vs VS Code
- R Dev Guide improvements
 - C for R contributors doc (building on <http://adv-r.had.co.nz/C-interface.html>)?
- US R Dev Day/Sprint 2027 - potential hosts?